bit and knew we had other games ahead of us and that was why he brought on Kieron Dyer. Even so, I wasn't happy about being substituted. It was the first time I'd ever felt angry about one of Mr Eriksson's decisions. Watching from the bench, I got more and more frustrated as the game drifted away to a draw.

The 1–1 scoreline wasn't a disaster for the first match of a major tournament, but we were really disappointed with our performance. I think that was why we didn't go over and thank the England fans inside the stadium after the final whistle. We were criticized for that in the papers the next day and accused of snubbing our fans, but that wasn't true. We'd had fantastic support and I think the players disappeared into the dressing room because we felt we hadn't lived up to it. What we did all realize afterwards was that, whatever the reason, not applauding our own fans was a mistake. As captain, maybe it was down to me to lead, even though I'd been on the bench. All the players talked about it together the following day and we promised ourselves and the supporters that, in future, we'd make sure we recognized them being there and behind us.

Back in the dressing room, it felt like we'd lost. I couldn't remember having seen this England team so flat. It was the first time I'd seen Sven really try to shake players out of a mood.

'We've got two big games ahead of us. Don't even think about letting yourselves get depressed about today. It's not a problem. We've drawn 1–1. We didn't lose, did we? Come on. What's wrong with you, lads?'

I'd not been in the best of moods myself, partly because I was still annoyed about the manager having taken me off. I hadn't expected that at all. I listened to Sven in the dressing room, though, and realized that, as captain, I should be doing what I could to be positive. It was still a pretty miserable evening.

The next day we had no choice but to forget about Sweden. We had four days to get ourselves ready for what was always going to be the biggest game in the group. Now, it was a game we really needed to win. One of the best things about Sven-Goran Eriksson as a manager is his ability to judge what players need at any particular time. He says the right things to have each individual in the right frame of mind for a game. Just as important is that he always seems to know exactly what we need physically as well. Between games, in a situation like a World Cup, he works hard when the team will benefit from that but he'll ease up in training sessions if our bodies aren't up to it. He wasn't going to 'punish' us with a schedule because we hadn't played